

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 571

By Massey

A RESOLUTION to urge the Tennessee Department of Transportation to establish habitat and no-mow areas on highway rights-of-way for the monarch butterfly.

WHEREAS, the General Assembly recognizes that monarch butterflies are a critical part of the ecosystem in North America, including the Volunteer State, and that they are in grave danger of extinction due in part to the destruction of their natural habitat in Mexico and the United States and, in particular, here in Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, monarch butterflies winter in Mexico and then journey through the United States, with some reaching as far as Canada during the summer months before returning to Mexico; and

WHEREAS, milkweed plants are critical to the survival of monarch butterflies because that is the only place where they lay their eggs, and milkweed plants are the only source of food for monarch caterpillars; without milkweed, there would be no monarch butterflies; and

WHEREAS, the construction of roads, shopping centers, subdivisions, and other development has resulted in the destruction of most growths of milkweed in Tennessee and elsewhere in the United States; and

WHEREAS, frequent mowing of rights-of-way and the use of herbicides have led to very little milkweed/monarch butterfly habitat being left in Tennessee and elsewhere in the United States; and

WHEREAS, in addition to needing milkweed for laying eggs and feeding the larvae, the species also need wildflowers of all kinds in order to feed adult butterflies; and

WHEREAS, there is a tremendous amount of road and highway rights-of-way in Tennessee that can be used for planting milkweed and other wildflowers; and

WHEREAS, if significant sections of road and highway rights-of-way in Tennessee were dedicated to growing milkweed and other wildflowers, it could make a huge difference in the ability of monarch butterflies to survive; and

WHEREAS, the dedication of rights-of-way to milkweed and wildflowers could result in significant cost savings in mowing expenses; and

WHEREAS, large plantings of wildflowers along Tennessee highways would give travelers something to notice and remember and make them want to come back, whether that be as tourists or residents; and

WHEREAS, other states are already using highway rights-of-way to provide habitat for monarch butterflies, including the Interstate 35 Monarch Butterfly Highway from Texas to Minnesota; and

WHEREAS, the route of monarch butterflies via I-40, I-75, and I-81, and other highways through Tennessee is just as vital to monarch butterflies as the route along I-35; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we hereby urge the Tennessee Department of Transportation to consider dedicating significant sections of road and highway rights-of-way for milkweed and other native wildflowers in order to provide habitat for monarch butterflies.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we also urge the Tennessee Department of Transportation to identify sections of rights-of-way where milkweed or wildflowers are presently growing and to refrain from mowing those areas.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that a certified copy of this resolution be transmitted to the Commissioner of Transportation.